



Palm Island Community Company

Impact Evaluation Highlights



Acknowledgements

We would like to thank the Traditional Owners the Manbarra people, Elders, Bwgcolman people, Palm Island Community Company Staff and Palm Island stakeholders who graciously welcomed us into their world, so we could observe and listen. We would also like to thank the members of the Evaluation Advisory Group, Board members and government stakeholders, without whose input the evaluation would not have not been possible. A number of Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander people worked hard on Palm Island to make this research and report happen. We would like to thank the local researchers for their insight and wisdom and for keeping the integrity of the voices in our research findings.

Ipsos acknowledges the Traditional Owners of the water, land and sea. Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander peoples who contributed to this research shared with us accumulated knowledge that encompasses spiritual relationships, relationships between people, relationships with the natural environment and the sustainable use of natural resources. This knowledge is reflected in language, narratives, social organisation, values, beliefs and cultural laws and customs. We respect that this knowledge is not static like the written word but responds to change through absorbing new information and adapting to its implications. Therefore, we wish to acknowledge Palm Island Community Company and the Manbarra and Bwgcolman people of Palm Island as joint custodians of these evaluation findings.

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Letter from the Chair of the Board and CEO

On behalf of the PICC Board, I am very pleased to receive this report on the PICC evaluation. The project has been a truly collaborative effort. While initiated and managed by PICC, the evaluation would not have been possible without the participation and financial support of the Queensland Government agencies, (DATSIP, Child Safety and Communities) and the independent expertise of the IPSOS team.

The evaluation findings provide evidence to inform the future directions and priorities for PICC. In particular they confirm the timeliness of the PICC Board's decision to seek shareholder agreement to transition PICC to full community control. This is a significant move and we look forward to working with our key shareholders, the Palm Island Aboriginal Shire Council and the Queensland Government, as well as our staff and the community, to ensure that PICC remains a strong, well-governed organisation and meets the needs of the community.

The many achievements detailed in this report are the result of much hard work over many years by the PICC Board, management and staff as well as the support we have received from government and many other partners and stakeholders. The support of Alf Lacey, Mayor Palm Island Aboriginal Shire Council in particular has been a highly valued contribution to the evolution of PICC. We should all be proud of our success in creating local employment and the central role local staff play in service delivery.

The evaluation has also given us an opportunity to identify those areas we need to improve and change and we are determined to do just that so that Palm Island has the very best services possible.

We are committed to building on our strengths and working with the community towards self-determination, a better life for all Bwgcolman people and a strong community.



A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Rachel Atkinson'.

Rachel Atkinson - CEO



A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to be a stylized 'M'.

Mislam Sam - Chair of the Board

Evaluation highlights

Palm Island Community Company (PICC) represents a unique governance and service delivery model that has now been operational for over 10 years. PICC is a stable vehicle that attracts state and federal government funding to supply a variety of services on Palm Island. It helps connect Palm Island residents with the right services at the right time and helps to reduce cost of living on Palm Island through local social enterprises. A change in governance from government to community control shareholding is pending. PICC commissioned Ipsos' Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Research Unit to undertake this independent impact evaluation of its effectiveness and to ensure its future directions are informed by reliable and robust evidence. The evaluation has *assessed the outcomes achieved to date, achievements made, the factors contributing to success and the areas for improvement or change* in governance, administration, service delivery and stakeholder engagement.

The evaluation draws on evidence from:

- reviewed documentation, performance reports, government statistics, funding contracts, past evaluations, past economic impact analysis, annual reports and governance documentation
- primary data collected by Ipsos from stakeholders (n=37) and community (n=113) interviews
- primary data collected by PICC from staff (n=51) and community (n=131 of which 98 had used services)
- literature from the Queensland Productivity Commission, Empowered Communities, the National Partnership Agreement on Remote Service Delivery, Stronger Communities for Children and SNAICC.

Key Achievements

- **Workforce** – As at March 2019, the workforce comprises 98 people of whom 85% are Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander peoples and 78% are locals of Palm Island. Within the current cohort, 55% have some form of formal qualification.
- **Governance** – As at March 2019, four of the Board members, including the Chair, are local Palm Islanders and two are non-indigenous.
- **Clients** – In 2018, 3306 clients used a range of PICC services, including 784 unique patients presenting at the Clinic. The 3306 are unique cases to each service; however, some people may have accessed multiple services. PICC services are improving the social and emotional wellbeing of Palm Island residents.
- **Service delivery** – In 2018, PICC was funded for 17 different services or programs by 11 funding organisations across state and federal governments. Quality Accreditation and relevant licencing has been achieved every year.
- **Community** – PICC has facilitated community members' involvement in policy development by helping them participate in reform agendas, most notably the Child Safety Reforms and in ensuring recognition of cultural authority in the Family Participation Program. PICC has also facilitated community voice at a local level through supporting Elders Group, Justice Group, DFV Network, Art Group and Rugby League.
- **Social enterprises** – PICC is creating a new narrative that moves Palm Island from a welfare economy to a place of profit-for-purpose enterprises that provide affordable goods and services, creating local employment opportunities.

- **Strengthening the economy** – economic impact analysis in 2016 of PICC services and employment on Palm Island show \$9.75 million generated in economic output and \$8 million added in Gross Regional Product. Compared to similar communities, the Palm Island community has a higher (equivalised) median household income, stronger employment participation rates and less rental stress.

Main success factors

The evaluation undertaken by Ipsos has identified the following success factors leading to the performance of, achievements and outcomes of PICC. This input for this assessment is based upon stakeholder and community feedback and survey and interview findings, internal and external stakeholder feedback and service provider feedback as well as an interpretation of effectiveness undertaken by Ipsos in drawing evaluation conclusions.

- **Local Indigenous knowledge** – The local Palm Islanders working for PICC ensure that culturally safe services are delivered appropriately.
- **Local Indigenous leadership** – The Palm Islander Board members ensure that strategic leadership directs PICC to best meet community needs. There are currently four Indigenous and two non-Indigenous Board members.
- **Connector** – PICC is improving health and wellbeing outcomes through empowering Bwgcolman families and the Palm Island community. PICC helps connect Palm Island residents with the right services at the right time and facilitates the connection between families and highly specialised human services providers.
- **Economies of scale** – The number of PICC's funding agreements has created economies of scale resulting in some efficiency and productivity gains but some gaps in funding sources remain in the provision of wraparound holistic service.

- **Economic integration** – A larger client base provides economic integration and an environment for community-controlled organisations to grow, become more productive and compete with larger NGOs.

Challenges

It has been challenging for PICC to gain the support of the community for a number of reasons.

Funding modality – The disconnect between how services and programs are funded and how they need to be delivered can result in negative community perceptions attributed to PICC, which is caught in the middle between community expectations and government policy. PICC is trying to work within the funding agreements to best meet community needs and be accountable to funders. Its actions are often misunderstood by the community, which affects the level of generalised trust in the organisation.

Governance model – PICC has two Ordinary Shareholders, Palm Island Aboriginal Shire Council and the Queensland Government. The latter has generated negative community perceptions about the level of local decision-making authority that PICC Board members or the community in general have. Communication around how PICC supports the community have not been successful, and the community grapevine becomes the main source of information about PICC.

Lateral violence – Some of PICCs achievements are sometimes undervalued by particular individual or a small group of stakeholders. The Community and Staff survey findings reported levels of lateral violence behaviours amongst the population and PICC has been subject to excessive compliance activities from government based on inaccurate information it received. PICC has worked hard to change how government does business with the community to improve the lives of the Bwgcolman families. Nevertheless, PICC continues to work in an environment where the experiences of local people are

influenced by the past and present government policies of remote and discrete Aboriginal communities which foster the development of lateral violence behaviours. Lateral violence is a very complex challenge and must be addressed in conjunction with broader measures to address trauma associated with colonialism.

Areas for strengthening

Led by feedback from stakeholders, service providers and community surveys and consultation, Ipsos has identified that critical areas that could be improved for overall better outcomes relate to:

- Better communication with community members to build generalised trust in PICC
- Address lateral violence and develop approaches that identify and manage complaints.
- Succession planning for senior management roles and Board members to ensure the longevity and stability of PICC.
- Improvement of human resources systems and processes to ensure employee wellbeing and safety is increased.
- Better measurement of impact indicators.

It is acknowledged that PICC already has strategies in place to address many of the HR staffing and system issues identified in this report; although addressing these to the extent required will take time to appropriately identify and build capability of the PICC workforce beyond that which already exists and to identify and implement more sophisticated (but cost effective) HR systems.

It is also acknowledged that while PICC may need to consider how to improve its reputation, communicate with the community and establish a system for better measurement of its impact and positive community outcomes that these are also significant tasks and that no current funding is available to expedite these agendas.

EVALUATION SUMMARY

The evaluation finds that PICC has positive impacts and achievements. However, community members' perceptions are very mixed about what PICC is doing to contribute to improving life on Palm Island. The findings contribute to broader policy deliberations about community-controlled service delivery in remote and discrete communities but better understanding the challenges experienced and success factors developed by PICC.

Optimal impact is achieved when PICC is relevant, efficient, effective and sustainable.

RELEVANT

PICC is relevant (wanted and valued) by most community and stakeholders. Almost all staff surveyed (91%) felt that working for PICC allows them to contribute to making a positive difference in their community and that PICC was focused on achieving positive outcomes for the Palm Island community.

The Queensland Government StatShot dataset (see Evaluation Findings section of the full report) of Palm Island shows disparity in a range of indicators between this population and the Queensland population. This means that highly specialised human services are needed.

PICC provides human services that are critical to the needs of Palm Island residents. Not all residents are aware of or need these services; however, the 3306 clients who do use them need them and want and value them. To deliver the right services to the right people at the right time in the right way requires skilled local staff and cultural knowledge. PICC has enabled approximately 400 Aboriginal and/or Torres Strait Islander staff an opportunity for employment and to develop their skills and capacity. PICC has been able to contribute to improving programs and policies through thought leadership, advocating for community members, consulting with community, showing

compassion and challenging the status quo.

The literature supports community-led decision-making, self-determination and empowerment as important mechanisms for improving health and wellbeing indicators.

A model of Indigenous leadership and Indigenous knowledge is needed to have an impact.

The reputation of PICC is mixed, with diverse views from community and stakeholders about what value it provides to the community. This is largely historical negativity, which is slowly changing. The move to a community controlled governance model brings opportunity for PICC to shape how it wants the community to view it and better communication about PICC's social change goals and successes associated with a profit-for-purpose model.

EFFICIENT

Palm Island is an expensive place to do business, which affects all areas of operation. PICC staff feel it does have a very lean administration structure, despite some community members and stakeholders having the perception that overheads are high.

A large pool of highly skilled local Palm Island staff fill most of the frontline positions in PICC. However, a community this size cannot support full-time specialist professionals so these are well coordinated and integrated as needed from Townsville and elsewhere. Due to the cost and unavailability of housing on Palm Island, fly-in/fly-out (FIFO) workers ensure that the skilled workforce is maintained. This approach remains more cost-effective than relocation for highly skilled professional staff.

PICC has been financially stable and well managed, but it is growing rapidly. It is outgrowing its current policies, systems and processes, which are not always robust and efficient enough to meet the needs of the organisation as it increases in size.

EFFECTIVE

Stakeholders and staff say that without PICC it

would be very difficult to connect individuals, families and the community to the right services they need at the right time. Services say that working with PICC enables them to deliver culturally appropriate services and to engage with clients and community.

The term 'connector' seems to be a good way to describe the ability of PICC to effectively engage, refer and collaborate with clients because the local staff know how to relate to the Palm Island community, and the managers know how to work with the stakeholders they partner with.

As well as connecting people to services, PICC also delivers effective high quality funded services, evidenced by program performance reports, quality audits and client outcomes. PICC has had to be creative and innovative to maximise potential outcomes from what may be limited, constrained or short sighted, or short term funding agreements.

SUSTAINABLE

The commitment by and approach of the Board and the model of operation have changed a serious, fragmented and unstable community situation to one that provides ongoing positive community-level impacts.

It is important to recognise the success PICC has had to date in being a sustainable and well-governed organisation since it started given the issues that existed at commencement, the complexity of working in remote communities, and in the context of the active barriers and challenges created by government policy.

Over this journey it has been essential to rely on external expertise and management to drive performance and strategy in PICC. However, this may need to evolve to provide greater community control in the future and using expert consultants for specific needs. The stability of governance in a new community-controlled model will be critical if PICC is to continue to provide valued high quality human services and employment opportunities for the Palm Island community.

IMPACT

The main impact of PICC for Palm Island is that there is a stable organisation sufficiently equipped to support rapid growth in Indigenous employment and, as a result, in culturally appropriate service delivery.

Quantitative data from this evaluation suggests PICC is impacting positively on many different levels to improve life outcomes on Palm Island (e.g. health and child safety). Financial and crime statistics available show improvements in these areas within the community and a stronger position than similar Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities, for example:

- 15 businesses which exceeds business prevalence in similar communities
- A higher weekly equivalised median of \$456 than similar communities (\$402)
- A greater employment participation rate of 41.6% compared to similar communities (39.5%)
- Reduction in rates of offences against the person and drug offences over the past five years and lower rates in these offences in comparison to similar communities.
- Lower rates in offences against property compared to similar communities.

Despite some positive evidence of impact, there is anecdotal recognition that there is more work to be done and scope to achieve further positive outcomes.

Ipsos recommends that PICC establish a system of measuring their impact via a community dashboard of qualitative and quantitative data using Indigenous knowledge and Indigenous data sovereignty principles. This will help inform decision making and support evidencing the success or otherwise of the community controlled model of governance. It is acknowledged that there is no funding available and identified for this administrative process at this time and that PICC may not wish to divert resources to this against the priority of service delivery and client outcomes.



The real strength of PICC is in the number of local people they employ. Good jobs are well paid and this flows on to families' wellbeing and then there are households with a working person as a role model. Our children will see this and it will mean we can write our future.

The governance model of PICC was what Palm Island needed 10 years ago, to create a stable organisation to deliver quality services utilising highly skilled staff and board members.

It is time now for the future of PICC to transition to a community controlled governance model to optimise self-determination and build on the current highly skilled staff and board members.

EVALUATION OF THE PICC MODEL

The development of the PICC model took a considerable time from conception to implementation, in part because it was complex and controversial within government and within the community. PICC was established to achieve:

- good governance and a high level of accountability
- sufficient scale to be cost-effective and financially sustainable
- direct delivery of high quality, effective social services
- improved community capacity
- improved social wellbeing
- economic development.



SUMMARY

Good governance and a high level of accountability

- ✓ YES, and a communications strategy has promoted organisational strengths to community and stakeholders to increase corporate reputation.

Sufficient scale to be cost-effective and financially sustainable

- ✓ Historically YES; however, the next phase of community-controlled health will require PICC to step up another level in organisational structure and capacity.

Direct delivery of high quality, effective social services

- ✓ OFTEN, and more developmental evaluation would improve the refinement of practices and procedures to achieve better client outcomes. PICC will need to consider its role as connector and collaborate to ensure other specialised service providers coming to Palm Island are delivering high quality services.

Improved community capacity

- ✓ YES, and appreciation for the staged and incremental capacity building of staff as a significant achievement and ongoing goal as the organisation grows.

Improved social wellbeing

- ✓ YES at a client level but hard to tell at a community level as the data has limitations and attribution to PICC is difficult.
- ✓ YES as children are not entering out-of-home care, and more work is needed to reunify children currently in care with their families.
- ✓ YES and appreciation for the positive effect that employment of local people in PICC has on the health and wellbeing of their families.

Economic development

- ✓ YES and appreciation that without a local vehicle to attract funding, there may have been less social services spending and jobs in community.
- ✓ YES and appreciation that social enterprises are a long-term strategy to self determination.

Palm Island Community Company

Summary of the Palm Island Community Company

Sources: 2018 and 2019 PICC Administration data, 2017-18 audited financial records, 2017 PICC Staff Survey and 2018 PICC Community Survey

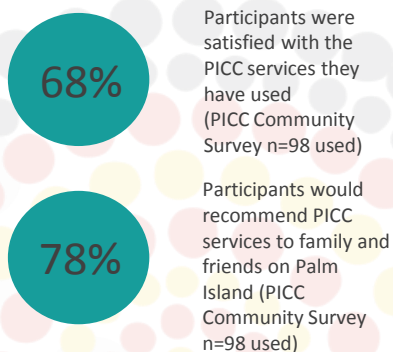
3306 Clients serviced in 2018

	Number of Clients	Male	Female
Disability Service	18	6	12
Diversionary Service	447	258	189
Hub Counselling	106	2	104
Safe Haven	713	370	343
The Hub	311	38	273
Youth Patrol	758	403	355
Medical Service (unique patients)	784	383	401
Women's Services	148	0	148
Safe House	21	13	8

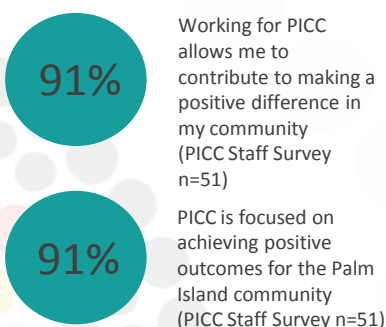
Revenue of \$8,974,803 (2017/18)

\$6,466,435	Grant funding
\$918,400	Sales of goods
\$519,685	Medicare income
\$373,500	Wage subsidy
\$167,641	Grant funding
\$164,526	Practice incentive payments
\$101,520	Rental income
\$263,096	Other

Client satisfaction



Staff satisfaction



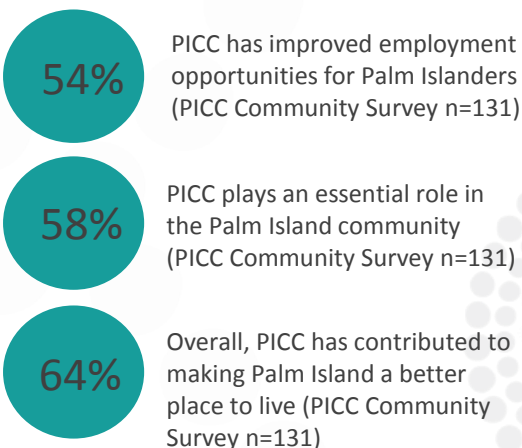
98 Employees in 2019

83

Indigenous staff

15

Non-Indigenous staff

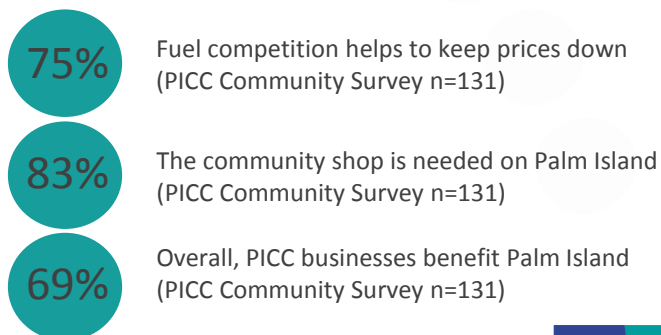


17 Funding agreements in 2017/18

Funding agreements for service delivery in 2017/18 with 11 different agencies in the following sectors:

- 4 Health
- 3 Domestic and family violence
- 3 Families and children
- 3 Early childhood
- 1 Financial assistance
- 1 Youth
- 1 Disability
- 1 Diversionary

3 Social enterprises





The full report is available on the PICC website

www.picc.com.au